

THE HEAVENS RISING

Book Two of the Heavens Gates Chronicles



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By Robert Leon Geter II

*A novel of proof, expansion, power, and the
dangerous attention success attracts.*

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Dedication

Dedicated to those who survived the cage without letting the cage
become their only language.

To those who built in silence while the world mistook their patience
for weakness.

And to those who learned that proof is the most dangerous form of
prophecy.

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Opening Note

Book One ended with a declaration.

Book Two begins with proof.

But before the system could rise in public, Barry Parker had to survive the years that punishment carved into him. So this book opens not with celebration, but with consequence. Not with applause, but with the long shadow that followed the first stain.

For what rises in power is always shaped by what it first survived in silence.

Chapter One — Of the Stain and the Years That Followed

Death reached Barry before the law finished its work.

Not death in the final sense. Not his own. But that other kind of death that clings to a person after blood, fear, and consequence have already entered him and found a room to stay in.

When he made it back to his aunt's house in Inkster, she knew it before he opened his mouth. Some women from that generation did not need confession. They read the spirit first. She looked at him one long time and felt what had crossed over with him. Felt the violence. Felt the panic. Felt the wrongness. Felt that something had attached itself to the boy before he could outrun it.

"You need to go home," she told him.

Not tomorrow. Not after sleep. Not after food.

Home.

South.

Back where the blood could cover what the city had sharpened.

But consequence was already moving faster than prayer.

There had been a witness.

And before Barry could get on the road, Detroit police found him.

That was how the years opened.

Not with understanding. Not with redemption.

With a cage.

He would do eight years for that stain, until he turned twenty-one. And in those years, the boy who thought survival was a moment learned that survival was also duration.

He learned how time can flatten weaker men and refine stronger ones. He learned how noise behaves when it is trapped in cinder block. He learned that some men get swallowed by confinement because they arrive in it already hollow, while others become more dangerous because confinement forces them to look at what remains when every distraction has been stripped away.

Barry Parker did not come out of those years innocent.

He came out measured.

He came out quieter.

He came out with a greater hatred for waste, weakness, performance, and systems that fed off the undisciplined.

He came out understanding that if a man ever meant to build something righteous, he first had to learn how not to be ruled by panic, appetite, or the need to be seen.

And when he stepped back into Detroit at twenty-one, he did not yet know what he would become.

He only knew this:

he had survived long enough to owe the future something.

Chapter Two — Of the Cage, the Silence, and the Young Man Released

Barry did not leave confinement with a ready-made plan.

That part would come later.

What he left with first was discipline.

The kind that does not brag on itself. The kind that gets into a man's bones because he has watched too many others unravel from a lack of it. He had seen boys enter locked space still trying to impress ghosts. Seen grown men talk themselves into weakness. Seen rage turn repetitive and then pathetic. Seen false toughness dissolve the minute time stopped moving fast enough to flatter it.

Barry learned to listen more. To watch more. To calculate the hidden cost of foolishness more clearly. He learned that some mistakes do not merely hurt. They alter the architecture of a life.

So when he came out at twenty-one, Detroit did not receive a boy trying to prove he had been through something.

It received a young man trying to understand what could still be made from what remained.

He moved carefully at first. Temporary rooms. Temporary jobs. Temporary faces around him. The city was still big enough to

swallow a man who had no system. Barry knew that. He had seen too much not to. He knew that getting out was not the same thing as becoming free. Plenty of men left cages only to re-enter other ones made of pride, fast money, bad loyalty, or hunger without architecture.

Barry did not want that kind of freedom.

He wanted footing.

And though he had not yet named it, what he was already searching for was structure.

Chapter Three — Of Makaila and the Second Becoming

He met Makaila during the years when both of them were still deciding what kind of power they intended to become.

She was younger than him by five years, soft-spoken in that country way that made careless people underestimate her, and sharp enough with numbers to be dangerous before most men even understood the shape of the threat. Eastover had raised one side of her. Detroit had sharpened another. She knew money trails, appearances, leverage, and the way institutions could be bent by people who understood their vanity better than their rules.

Barry saw immediately that she had a rare mind.

Not just for counting.

For translating structure.

She saw very quickly that Barry was not ordinary either. He did not move like the other men trying to make themselves look important.

He had silence in him. Weight in him. A strange patience that made him seem older than he was. He did not talk like a dreamer with no map. He talked like somebody who had already paid for some of his principles in blood and years.

That was the first bond.

Not romance.

Recognition.

They would become more to each other later. But first they were two people noticing that the other had the kind of mind that could either build kingdoms or ruin a great many fools.

And somewhere in that season, while Detroit kept testing both of them in different ways, Barry's second becoming began.

Chapter Four — Of Heavens Gates and the Proof of the System

Return to the present.

The declaration had already been made.

Now came the more dangerous part:

proof.

Heavens Gates was no longer just a promising idea, no longer just one hidden studio, one rescued artist, one singer with soul, one engineer with order in his hands. It had become a working system. Sessions moved. Songs moved. Videos moved. Money moved. Small businesses tied to the culture began to breathe easier. Not through miracle money. Through consistency.

That was what made the movement dangerous.

Consistency.

Because a Black-owned system that works once can be dismissed as luck.

A Black-owned system that works repeatedly becomes a threat.

The old South Beltline building no longer felt like a skeleton. It had lungs now. Cars came and went at all hours. Not in the sloppy way of a trap spot or the desperate way of some local vanity label trying to create the appearance of motion. Heavens Gates moved with rhythm. Engineers showed up because they were needed. Artists showed up because there was actual work to do. Camera crews came through because videos were being cut with enough frequency to feed not just performers, but editors, stylists, and whole little side circles of people finally finding a lane that paid them something steady.

That was Barry's deeper satisfaction.

Not the applause.

Not the image.

The fact that an ecosystem had started breathing on its own.

By then, there were younger brothers in Columbia who had stopped saying they wanted to "blow up" and started saying they wanted to build. That shift mattered more to Barry than any single record. It meant the language itself was changing. Men who had once thought success meant a chain, a feature, and a borrowed room were beginning to imagine rooms of their own. Young women who had once thought the only way in was through proximity to some greedy local operator were seeing examples of female artists, singers, stylists, and coordinators moving through a different kind

of structure.

This was not wealth yet in the grand sense.

But it was circulation.

And circulation is what keeps a people from mistaking inspiration for economy.

In small pockets all over Columbia, proof kept appearing. A producer paid his rent off tracking sessions and beat placements without having to beg a bigger city for permission. A camera boy turned himself into an actual video man, then into a media company with two younger shooters under him. A girl who started off sewing jackets for two artists now had half the local scene asking for custom pieces. A printer with enough discipline to stay open late started making regular money from flyers, inserts, posters, promo materials, and album packaging because Heavens Gates believed in making the visual side look like it mattered.

It did matter.

Barry had never believed music was just music.

Music was the center current, yes. But around it lived image, fashion, storytelling, distribution, production, memory, and the possibility of economic organization. He had always seen that more clearly than the city did. Now the city was beginning to see it too.

That was why the proof had weight.

Not because it made a few stars.

Because it made a working lane.

In one of the upstairs offices, Barry sat late one evening with papers spread across the desk and a legal pad full of figures. He was not smiling. That was never really his way. But there was a settled

satisfaction in him that only came when vision became measurable. Session logs. Equipment lists. Rent costs. Studio upgrades. Video bookings. Artist allocations. Performance earnings. Merch movement. He looked at the numbers the way some men look at the horizon—measuring not only what had already happened, but what it meant for where they could go next.

Makaila came in, glanced at the sheets, and knew from his face that the numbers were speaking in his favor.

“Well?” she asked.

Barry leaned back in the chair.

“It’s breathing,” he said.

Makaila’s eyes moved over the papers without needing the whole explanation.

“Not just breathing,” she said. “Multiplying.”

Barry gave the slightest nod.

That was the proof.

It was no longer just one set of books inside one building.

It was a pattern.

And patterns are what empires pay attention to when they begin deciding whether something should be partnered with, contained, bought, or broken.

Barry knew that too.

Proof, after all, does not only attract belief.

It attracts enemies.

Chapter Five — Of Gangsta, Sarah Rae, and the Front of the Sound

Every movement has a public face whether it wants one or not.

For Heavens Gates, two names increasingly carried that burden: Lil Gangsta and Sarah Rae.

They were not alike in form. That was part of the power.

Gangsta came through with pressure, witness, hunger, and the kind of raw city credibility that could not be bought by flyers or faked through styling. When he spoke on a record, people believed there was consequence behind the words, not just performance. But something else had changed in him since Barry pulled him off that night outside the venue. He no longer sounded like a boy trying to prove he was dangerous. He sounded like a young man learning how to place danger inside thought, rhythm, and meaning.

That made him heavier.

Sarah Rae worked differently.

Where Gangsta sounded like the city's heartbeat under pressure, Sarah Rae sounded like its older memory. Her voice carried that rare thing people call soul when they are trying to summarize an inheritance too deep to explain plainly. She could sing a line and make it feel like the room had suddenly grown an extra generation inside it. Men stopped talking when she worked. Women listened harder than they first meant to. Even people who did not know how to describe what made her different knew she carried a frequency too old and too true for trend.

Together, they became the front of the sound.

Not because Barry staged them like puppets.

Because the public naturally began reading them that way.

The city needed symbols. It always had. It needed living examples of what a thing looked like when it crossed from idea into embodiment. Gangsta and Sarah Rae became that. On one side, Black male survival and force being redirected toward creation. On the other, Black female spiritual gravity refusing to be flattened into industry fashion.

And the records reflected that balance.

They did not sound like local approximations of whatever Atlanta, New York, or Los Angeles happened to be pushing. They sounded like Columbia learning how to hear itself with greater clarity. The records held church dust and project air, porch memory and parking-lot tension, old warnings and new temptation. They made room for beauty without losing grit, and made room for pressure without glorifying stupidity.

That distinction mattered.

By then, people had started showing up to Heaven's Gates functions not just to hear what was playing, but to see who might emerge next. Mothers brought daughters around Sarah Rae hoping some part of her steadiness might rub off. Younger boys hung around Gangsta with that mixture of admiration and caution the streets always give a young boss when he has started turning into something they do not fully understand yet.

Gangsta felt that pressure more than he admitted.

One night after a late session, he and Barry stood outside the building listening to the low hum of the city moving in the distance. Gangsta had a blunt in one hand and the kind of reflective quiet on him that only showed up when the room had finally emptied and no performance was required.

“You ever think about how people be looking at this?” he asked.

Barry kept his eyes ahead.

“How you mean?”

Gangsta shrugged.

“Like... they hearing these records, yeah. But that ain’t all they hearing.”

Barry let that sit. He liked when the younger men around him discovered meaning on their own instead of being force-fed it.

“Go on,” he said.

Gangsta exhaled smoke slow.

“They hearing what it could look like if we ain’t just out here crashing. If we actually build. If we actually keep our shit.”

Barry glanced at him once, then back toward the street.

“That’s why you can’t move careless no more,” he said.

Gangsta nodded, like he had already known the lesson but needed to hear it outside himself.

Sarah Rae carried that same awareness in a different way. She knew people heard more than notes when she sang. She knew women in the city, especially the older ones, listened to whether her voice felt rooted or borrowed. She knew little girls were watching how she stood, how she answered men, how she moved through rooms with softness that did not equal weakness.

The burden did not crush her.

It refined her.

That was why she and Gangsta worked.

They were not just successful artists.

They were examples.

And examples, when they become public, alter what a community believes is possible.

Barry understood the risk in that.

The higher people lifted them symbolically, the more careful the structure around them had to become. That was another part of leadership most local operators never learned. A gifted artist is not just talent to exploit or face to market. A gifted artist is a vessel. And vessels under public pressure either get protected, corrupted, or sacrificed.

Barry had no intention of sacrificing these.

Not if the system held.

Chapter Six — Of Asad and the Quiet Builders

The public saw the artists first.

That was natural.

But systems do not survive on public faces alone. They survive because quieter people keep the rhythm from collapsing behind the scenes. That was where Asad Jones became indispensable.

By the second year of Heavens Gates truly moving, Barry had already fallen further behind the scenes by design. He had no need to stand in the middle of every room once the right people had learned how to carry function. He still watched. Still decided. Still

rearranged pieces when deeper strategy called for it. But the day-to-day sound of the system increasingly belonged to men like Asad.

Asad carried himself with the same serious stillness he always had, only now there was greater authority beneath it. At nineteen he had first looked like a promising young engineer with a good ear and unusual discipline. By now he looked like something more dangerous: a builder who knew why every room worked.

He knew how to wire a studio and how to read the mood of a session before it fell apart. He knew when a young artist needed patience and when they needed a sharper word. He knew how to tell whether a beat was weak, whether a vocal needed another take, whether an engineer was hiding behind effects instead of cleaning the source. He knew how to track inventory, how to keep time blocks moving, how to schedule around personalities, how to fix small failures before they ripened into bigger ones.

That was the part the city never applauded.

And that was the part Barry respected most.

One afternoon Asad stood in the hallway outside Studio B with a clipboard in one hand and a coil of cable in the other, answering three questions at once while a beat leaked under one door and a female vocalist ran scales in another room down the hall. A younger engineer kept talking too much, trying to prove he was advanced. Asad listened without rushing him, then corrected him in two sentences so clean the boy went quiet out of sheer recognition.

Across the hall, one of the interns had a camera battery problem. Downstairs, a Charleston artist wanted to know whether there was time for an extra mix pass before the ride back. Somewhere in the back room, a videographer needed a hard answer about when the green-screen space would be ready.

Asad handled all of it like the building was an instrument and he had learned where each note sat.

Barry watched that from the end of the hall for a while without announcing himself.

That was one of Barry's habits. He liked to see people in function when they thought no central eye was resting on them. It told him whether the role had truly entered them or whether they were still performing competency for approval.

Asad was no longer performing it.

He had become it.

Later that evening Barry called him into one of the side offices.

Asad came in, sat, and waited.

Barry appreciated that too. Too many young men believed leadership meant filling silence with words. Asad knew silence could also be work.

"You getting stronger," Barry said.

Asad gave the smallest shrug. "Trying to."

Barry shook his head once.

"No. You are."

That landed because Barry was not a man who handed out compliments for morale.

He continued.

"You understand the difference now between holding a room and being seen in it."

Asad thought about that a second, then nodded.

“Yeah.”

“What is it?” Barry asked.

Asad leaned forward slightly. “Being seen in the room make people feel you there. Holding the room make the room work whether they thinking about you or not.”

Barry’s face did not move much, but his approval sat there anyway.

“There it is.”

That was what Heavens Gates needed more of.

Not stars in every position.

Builders.

People who understood that culture only becomes infrastructure when enough quiet hands are willing to care about the things vanity ignores.

And Asad was not alone anymore. That too was part of the evolution. Around him were younger engineers, assistant editors, lighting boys growing into real technicians, camera kids becoming visual directors, administrative girls becoming true coordinators, interns learning the difference between hanging around and serving function. What Barry had first envisioned as a single system was already multiplying into layers.

Heavens Gates had artists, yes.

But it also had labor.

And labor, when disciplined and protected, is where movements become institutions.

Chapter Seven — Of Freek Setter and the New Frequency

The first time Freek Setter came through, the building changed shape around his sound before most people knew his name.

He was from Gadsden, country-rooted, not flashy in the obvious city way, and carried himself with that odd mixture of ease and distance some gifted men have when they know their mind is running on a level the room has not caught up to yet. He did not enter like he needed to impress anyone. That immediately made him easier for Barry to notice.

There are men who talk their talent before they prove it.

And there are men who let the room bend first.

Freek Setter belonged to the second kind.

His name started as a shortening of a phrase—“the frequency setter”—but after a while nobody needed the explanation. Once you heard what he did to a beat, you understood why the name stayed. He built patterns that seemed simple until the body had been sitting inside them for a full minute and realized it had slipped somewhere else mentally. Low 808s, yes, but not lazy ones. Piano lines that felt half-haunting and half-hypnotic. Space used as pressure. Repetition used like trance. You didn’t just nod to his music. You entered it.

Gangsta understood that immediately.

The first session where Freek Setter really let loose, Gangsta stopped mid-conversation and turned toward the speakers like somebody had called his spirit from down a hallway. Asad raised one eyebrow in that quiet way of his. Sarah Rae leaned against the wall and closed her eyes, not dramatically, just enough to listen with her whole body. Barry stood in the back with his arms folded

and did what he always did when something real entered a room:
he watched how other gifted people responded to it.

That told him plenty.

Freek Setter's sound did not overpower the Heavens Gates identity.

It expanded it.

That was important.

He brought in another layer of the state—country cadence, open-road loneliness, nighttime humidity, field memory, and a darker pulse that still knew how to dance with city pressure. Suddenly records that once felt strictly urban-Columbia now had a wider southern spell on them. The state started hearing itself in broader pieces.

That made Barry almost more satisfied than the records themselves.

Bridging sound is how you start bridging people.

One night, long after the building had thinned out, Freek Setter sat at the board with a half-finished instrumental rolling while Barry stood behind him.

"You hear rooms before they built," Barry said.

Freek Setter did not turn around right away.

"I hear spaces," he answered.

Barry nodded once.

"Difference?"

Freek Setter finally looked back over his shoulder.

"A room is where people go. A space is what happen to them when they get there."

Barry smiled with one side of his mouth.

That was the kind of answer he liked.

Because it meant the young producer did not just understand music.

He understood environment.

And environment is one of the deepest currencies in cultural power.

Soon enough, artists from other parts of South Carolina started asking for “that Freek Setter feel” on their records. Some wanted the exact thing and could not explain it. Others only knew they wanted whatever kept happening to their chest when those beats dropped. Local legends, young hopefuls, and side labels all began circling the same truth:

Heavens Gates was not only producing songs.

It was producing atmosphere.

And atmosphere travels farther than hype.

That was how the new frequency spread.

Chapter Eight — Of the State Gathered Through Music

The first great proof that Barry’s system was working did not come from any one hit record.

It came when South Carolina began arriving at the door in pieces.

Charleston came with a different polish and coastal pride, artists carrying sea-weather smoothness in their voice and the old port city’s complicated Black elegance in their style. Florence came with

hunger and a certain regional determination that sounded like men trying to force themselves into the bigger conversation. Orangeburg came with college air, church residue, and street energy braided together in unusual ways. Smaller towns came too—places the larger music machine barely remembered to account for until it was time to exploit them.

And all of them, sooner or later, found themselves crossing paths in or around Heavens Gates.

That was no accident.

Barry had been bridging the state quietly through music, rooms, respect, and reliable function. He did not run around making loud speeches about uniting South Carolina. He simply built the kind of place where the state's scattered talent could arrive and recognize one another without immediately defaulting to old regional ego.

That was harder than it sounds.

South Carolina, like many places, knew how to divide itself even inside Black culture. City versus country. Coast versus inland. Polished versus raw. College town versus project code. Men often guarded their local identity like a weapon because nobody had ever shown them a larger structure they could belong to without disappearing inside it.

Barry understood that. So he did not ask artists to abandon where they came from.

He made Heavens Gates strong enough to hold where they came from in relation to one another.

That was the genius of the confederation model.

A Charleston artist could come through and not feel swallowed by Columbia. A Florence label could bring its boys in and still retain

its own local law. A crew out of Orangeburg could learn the studio system, shoot the videos, move the product, and still leave with more identity than they arrived with because the structure had sharpened their understanding of what they actually had.

That was what interdependence looked like when it worked.

Not sameness.

Strength in right relation.

One summer weekend, the building looked like a map turned human. A singer from Charleston was in one room cutting harmonies over a beat Freek Setter had sent in from Gadsden. A Florence rapper was waiting on a mix pass downstairs while arguing with a videographer about scene order for a shoot the next morning. Two Orangeburg producers were posted in the common room listening to Gangsta explain why certain records needed more space between the bass and the vocal. Sarah Rae crossed the hall with a notebook in one hand and a cup in the other, stopping just long enough to correct a hook somebody had leaned too hard toward cliché.

Asad moved through all of it with steady authority, keeping time from collapsing into confusion. Barry floated in and out more like a shadow with intention than a host. Makaila handled the numbers nobody else was meant to worry about. And somewhere in the middle of it all, the state began sounding less like isolated scenes and more like a body forming.

That was bigger than music.

It meant old borders were softening.

Not disappearing. Softening.

And whenever borders soften under Black self-governed structure, somebody somewhere in the larger machine starts feeling the threat even before the sales sheets fully confirm it.

Barry already knew that.

Still, he let himself stand in the hallway that evening and listen to what had gathered.

Not just the beats.

The accents.

The slang.

The confidence.

The arguments.

The laughter.

The friction.

The cooperation.

A state, if it ever means anything real, is not simply land.

It is relation.

And for the first time, South Carolina's Black musical spirit was beginning to hear itself as more than scattered fragments.

That was one of Barry Parker's greatest accomplishments.

And it was only the beginning.

Chapter Nine — Of Expansion, Holdings, and the New Hall

Once the numbers stopped looking like survival and started looking like profit, Barry moved exactly how Makaila expected him to move: outward.

Heavens Gates had been grinding for more than two years by then. It was never a losing machine in spirit, but the rise had cost what real rises cost—time, setbacks, reinvestment, patience, hidden expenses, public doubt, private strain, and the kind of long discipline that breaks weaker men before the visible reward ever arrives. Barry understood all that. So when the books finally started showing a steadier good, he did not respond like a fool with newfound breathing room.

He expanded the holdings.

The old Sam's Club building off Sunset had looked dead to most people. To Barry it looked like capacity. Width. Parking. Flexibility. A place that could become several things at once instead of one thing loudly. That was always how he liked to think. A single-purpose building bored him unless it was serving some larger machine.

Within the year, the place had been transformed.

Part performance hall. Part circuit hub. Part retail corridor. A few sections were leased out to smaller businesses with enough promise and discipline to benefit from the traffic. Other sections remained under tighter control, because Barry had no intention of turning the place into random commerce just because the city loved to celebrate any Black-owned property that looked busy from the street.

He wanted function.

The performance hall became one of the more important pieces in the expanding Heaven's Gates world. Talent showcases ran through it. Affiliate labels booked their artists there. Regional acts from

Charleston, Florence, Orangeburg, and elsewhere in the state touched the stage, tested their draw, learned the room, and built circuit presence beyond their home pockets. Heaven's Gates artists headlined some nights, curated others, and occasionally used the place simply to study how the crowd was changing.

That was one of Barry's habits too. Even when something belonged to him, he still watched it like a student first.

He stood one night near the back of the hall while a crowd from three different cities moved to the same record. Gangsta had just come offstage. Sarah Rae was due up later. A younger affiliate act from Charleston had opened stronger than expected. Two small retailers in the leased spaces outside were already counting a better night than they used to see in a week. A videographer was arguing with a promoter about camera angles in the lobby while a group of teenagers stood near a merch table trying to figure out which tape to buy with the little money they had left.

That was what Barry liked to see.

Not hype.

Circulation.

The building was producing more than applause. It was producing contact, receipts, repetition, visibility, and another physical node in a system that kept proving it could hold weight. If South Beltline was the workshop, Sunset was becoming the town square.

And that mattered.

Because movements do not truly start to threaten old power until they can gather people in public under their own roof and keep the lights on while doing it.

Barry knew that.

So did Makaila.

Chapter Ten — Of Makaila, the Bed, and the Warning of Numbers

That night, after the hall had emptied and the city had settled into one of those humid Carolina silences where even the darkness feels damp, Barry and Makaila lay in bed with the kind of tired satisfaction only working people really understand.

Not fairytale softness.

Not emotional performance.

Just two people who had spent years building toward a moment and now had enough proof in the books to finally discuss the next move from strength instead of strain.

The sex had been the kind that comes easier when pressure has recently been answered by results. Afterward, Makaila lay across him for a while before shifting so she could see his face in the low light. Barry rested one hand in her locks and let the room stay quiet long enough for their breathing to settle back into speech.

It was she who turned the conversation first.

“Since we in the good now,” she said, “reinvest it.”

Barry looked at her but said nothing yet. He knew there was more in that sentence than the first layer.

“Not just back into ours,” she continued. “Into theirs too. The affiliate labels. Help them upgrade their infrastructure while we build ours bigger. If the whole body get stronger, the umbrella get stronger.”

Barry nodded slowly. He had already been thinking in that direction. One of the reasons he and Makaila worked so well was that she often arrived at the same conclusion through numbers that he reached through instinct and long-range vision.

She was not done.

“And invest in a small media company,” she said. “One that answer to us from jump. Not just freelancers and side favors. A real media arm.”

Barry let his fingers move through her locks.

“That make sense.”

“And a security company.”

That made him look down at her more directly.

“We already got a small army.”

Makaila lifted her head off his chest and met his eyes with that particular look she had when her certainty had already gone past debate.

“Then WE will have a bigger army.”

There was no venom in it.

No challenge for the sake of challenge.

Just trust-me force.

Barry squinted a little, studying her the way he studied any serious signal.

“Have you come across some threats to us?”

Makaila looked at him a second before answering, weighing not whether to tell him, but how much of the pattern she had already

named fully inside herself.

“Not threats exactly,” she said. “Not yet. But I been paying attention.”

Barry waited.

“The number of artists around the country talking openly about gang wars,” she said, “and not just talking. They rapping after they done actually killed people. Telling on themselves, telling on each other, feeding the same thing right back into the street.”

Barry’s face darkened in thought, not anger.

Makaila kept going.

“It’s spreading. Fast enough that it don’t matter whether Columbia invented it. If the spirit catch here, it’s here. And the spirit of this city ain’t no different from no other city in that sense. Hurt, pride, retaliation, hunger, boys wanting to be feared more than they want to live. Give that a soundtrack and enough visibility and it’ll touch here too.”

Barry saw the seriousness in her eyes and understood immediately that this was not one of her abstract financial cautions. This was security thought. Cultural thought. Survival thought.

He leaned down, kissed her, then pulled her back so that her head rested against his chest again. His hand moved through her locks in slow strokes while he thought.

He was not dodging the substance. Makaila knew that. When Barry shifted from direct response into tenderness and a new line of strategy, it often meant he had accepted the warning at a level deeper than agreement.

After a while he spoke.

“I want to tighten up on affiliation.”

Makaila stayed still and listened.

“This is a family,” he said. “And a family structure shall exist. We keep the label deal structure the same. But each label head gon’ have their own executive role. They gain the opportunity to build labels under them. Expand into other cities if they can hold it. But all under the Heaven’s Gates umbrella. That’s how they all eat.”

Makaila closed her eyes briefly. She knew that tone. That was Barry taking a warning and transmuting it into structure.

He had heard her.

Completely.

He would just answer the danger through architecture instead of anxiety.

That was his way.

And hers, too.

Chapter Eleven — Of Affiliation, Family, and the Tightening of Structure

Barry moved on the affiliation question within weeks.

Not with a loud summit.

Not with some fake-corporate retreat designed to flatter egos and dress confusion up as leadership.

He called the right people in quietly, sometimes one by one, sometimes in smaller circles, and began placing the new order in

them until the thing felt less like an announcement and more like an evolution they should have already expected.

By then, Heaven's Gates had grown enough that the older loose ways could no longer hold indefinitely. Too many artists. Too many sessions. Too many labels trying to rise in relation to one another. Too much money beginning to move in low but steady streams. Too many eyes from other cities landing on what was taking shape. The old version of "we all family" was no longer enough by itself.

Family needed law.

So Barry tightened the structure.

Each affiliate label head would function more explicitly like an executive under the Heaven's Gates umbrella. Their autonomy remained, but now it sat within a clearer family order. They could develop artists. Build out their own sub-labels. Expand into other cities. Create localized movements of their own. But the umbrella law remained central: shared loyalty, shared access, shared distribution standards, shared protection, shared economic flow, and no feeding external parasites at the expense of the whole body.

That was the shift.

Heavens Gates was moving from movement into hierarchy.

Not cold hierarchy.

Living hierarchy.

A structure where position came with responsibility, where rights came with duty, and where expansion was no longer just ambition but stewardship.

Some men resisted it in small ways at first. Not openly, because Barry had built too much proof for anybody serious to act confused about his authority. But resistance still showed itself where

resistance always does—in body language, in little ego questions, in side comments dressed as jokes, in the uncertain face of a man suddenly realizing he can no longer call himself independent while eating from a greater family system without also answering to it.

Barry handled all that with calm.

He was not trying to create obedience for its own sake.

He was trying to prevent the future from collapsing under the weight of undisciplined growth.

One evening at the Sunset building, he stood in one of the retail corridors after hours with three label heads and laid the matter out without extra flourish.

“If you gon’ build,” he said, “build with accountability. If you gon’ lead, lead knowing this ain’t just you no more. You got opportunity now to have labels under you, cities under your watch, young artists coming behind you. That mean something.”

Nobody interrupted him.

Barry looked at each of them in turn.

“This ain’t about owning people. This about making sure what we got don’t scatter just because it got bigger.”

One of the men, a Florence label head with more talent than maturity, asked, “So what if one of us want a whole separate run?”

Barry did not answer immediately.

Then he said, “Then make sure it’s separate enough to feed itself and honest enough not to lie about where it got sharpened.”

That settled the room.

Because that was another part of Barry's power—he did not fear a strong branch.

He feared false freedom built on stolen structure and borrowed discipline.

By the time the family order was fully in place, Heaven's Gates had become harder to penetrate and harder to imitate. The labels under the umbrella now had more road to grow, but they also had more obligation to the body that held them. That would matter later, when real outside pressure began to test who truly understood the difference between affiliation and family.

Makaila watched the whole tightening process with quiet approval.

That was the answer she had hoped for.

Not just more guards.

More order.

Because the best army in the world still rots if the law holding it together is weak.

Chapter Twelve — Of Slim Mac, Hector Guzman, and the Fool's Pressure

Slim Mac had become a man trying to act rich in a room that had already smelled the debt on him.

Money was draining out of his life in too many directions at once. Artists gone. Local credibility cracked. Label motion thinning. Street respect turning unstable because respect without visible power eventually starts mutating into pity, and men like Slim hate pity worse than they hate enemies.

His narcotics contact had been demoted. His legal trouble sat closer every month. His own little goon network looked less like a fear apparatus now and more like a collection of under-talented crash-outs clinging to whatever scraps of his importance remained. Still he kept dressing it up. Kept posturing. Kept walking into rooms as if decline had not already put its hand on his shoulder.

The worst pressure, though, came from above him in another lane entirely.

Hector Guzman.

Hector was not just Slim's plug.

He was also his music distributor.

That was part of what made the arrangement so ugly. Slim's drug line and his local music line were not separate roads that occasionally crossed. They were feeding each other through the same deeper network. Hector handled his flow on both ends—dope and product, poison and packaging. Soul and Fire Southern Division looked like a regional label outfit to most outsiders, but beneath that legitimate face was something older and more organized, something fed by cartel blood and distribution logic more ruthless than local hustlers ever fully grasped.

Hector was the kind of man who rarely raised his voice because structure had long ago taught him it did not need to. He was lighter on his feet than his size first suggested, spoke with a calm that made insult sound almost administrative, and wore good clothes without making a spectacle of them. Men like Slim often confused that kind of calm for softness right until the pressure arrived.

By this point Hector was asking the question that really mattered:

How did Barry Parker get Lil Gangsta?

Not just as artist.

As symbol.

As momentum.

As route.

Each time Hector asked, Slim answered worse. Sometimes with bluster. Sometimes with half-truths. Sometimes with the kind of local politics men use when they are hoping the larger machine will be satisfied by excuses it is far too experienced to accept.

Hector was not satisfied.

He was losing patience with the music side and playing games with the dope side to remind Slim who really controlled the floor beneath his feet. Short counts. Delays. Changes in quality. Moved deadlines. Pressure without explanation. Every move said the same thing in a different accent:

You are no longer in command of your own myth.

Slim felt it.

And because weak men often answer pressure with foolish speed, he started sending his goons to rob other dealers, trying to make up money and posture through theft instead of structure. It was bad business, bad street math, and worse timing. But Slim had stopped moving from discipline long ago. Now he was moving from insult.

That made him dangerous in the short term and doomed in the long one.

One night Hector sat across from him in a dim office above a distribution floor that smelled faintly of cardboard, cigarettes, and stale air conditioning.

Slim tried to keep his voice casual.

“I got it under control.”

Hector looked at him the way men look at dogs that no longer realize they have been judged.

“You say that every time,” he said.

Slim forced a little laugh.

“Because it be true.”

Hector tilted his head slightly.

“Then why do I keep hearing Barry Parker’s name and your numbers moving in opposite directions?”

Slim did not answer right away.

Hector continued.

“You let that man build a state while you were still pretending one room and a few weak contracts made you a king.”

That line cut because it was true.

Slim wanted to hate Barry for the rise, but beneath the hate was something worse:

recognition.

Barry had done what Slim had only ever performed.

And now the fool’s pressure was closing.

Chapter Thirteen — Of Drill, Imitation, and the Label Wars

By the time the music industry had fully figured out there was money in turning public conflict into entertainment, the damage had already started teaching itself to younger men.

That was the nature of the thing.

A style emerges in one place. A machine notices in another. The machine funds what is most volatile because volatility sells faster than wisdom, then pushes it wide enough that boys in cities with different histories begin mistaking imported destruction for authentic expression.

Barry had seen the pattern coming.

Makaila had felt it as threat before the city called it trend.

And now Columbia was getting touched by it.

A few younger rappers with less talent than nerve had started imitating the artists most visibly accepted by the larger system. Drill energy entered the local bloodstream not just as sound, but as behavior. Robberies turned into records. Shootings got referenced on tracks almost before the blood dried. Retaliation became lyric material. Lyric material became another retaliation. Men were no longer just using songs to posture after the fact. They were using songs as provocations, invitations, and public disrespect.

That fed the label wars in ways even Barry had not originally hoped to account for. What began as business rivalry and wounded ego between smaller camps started absorbing actual street conflict. Affiliate tensions sharpened. Loyalists to dead or dying structures tried to keep relevance through trouble. Some boys, too stupid or too desperate to understand what Heaven's Gates was actually building, thought the answer to structure was louder recklessness.

They did not understand that the machine had already decided it loved young Black men most when they turned themselves into

evidence and soundtrack at the same time.

That was why Barry hated the pattern.

Not because he feared rhythm, aggression, or even dark testimony in records.

He feared formatting.

He feared the moment when a whole generation begins to think destruction is a legitimate business model simply because they can point to examples being rewarded for it somewhere else.

One evening after a meeting with two affiliate heads trying to settle a smaller feud before it ripened into something uglier, Barry stood in the hallway with Makaila and said, “They learning the wrong lesson.”

Makaila knew exactly what he meant.

“They seeing the money attached to the corpse and not the machine behind it,” she said.

Barry nodded.

“That’s because the machine prefer it that way.”

And while Heavens Gates kept trying to build law, quality, and a confederation structure capable of feeding the state with consistency, the atmosphere around them kept growing more unstable. Records were being used to announce war. Boys with no elders in them were trying to fast-track themselves into infamy. Men too old to be leading the young toward foolishness were still taking checks to point them there.

The label wars were no longer simply local politics.

They had become spiritual weather.

And spiritual weather, once thick enough, attracts men in higher places who know exactly how to profit from the storm.

Chapter Fourteen — Of Alfred Wilson and the Men Above the Violence

The room was expensive in a way that did not need decoration to prove it.

Dark wood. Heavy leather. Sound swallowed by carpet thick enough to keep footsteps from announcing themselves. The kind of room where decisions could be made about thousands of lives without any of the men present having to ever smell what those decisions became on the street.

A small gathering of businessmen, local political players, and men adjacent to both sat around the table discussing the rising violence in Columbia and the surrounding areas. Publicly, each of them would later express concern in the approved language. Tragic. Troubling. Community crisis. Need for partnerships. Youth intervention. All the respectable phrases men use when they intend to monetize disaster without appearing monstrous.

Privately, the room felt different.

At the head of one side sat Alfred Wilson.

He was a tall middle-aged Black man with copper leathery skin and white hair cut low into a compact afro that made him look both elder and strangely unplaced in time. He did not fidget. Did not overtalk. Did not ask permission to dominate the room, white power structure included. He spoke with the authority of somebody who understood that real hierarchy is not always visible to outsiders and not always racial in the way ordinary people imagine it.

That was what unsettled the room when he spoke.

Not that he was Black.

That he sounded more in charge than the men many would have assumed he answered to.

“They are going in the right direction,” Alfred said.

The room quieted further.

One of the white men at the far end shifted in his chair, unsure whether the phrase meant what he feared it meant.

Alfred continued without helping him.

“In the future this will produce bigger profits and solidify our control amongst these peasants.”

He did not say it with a grin. That made it worse.

“So we feign disdain for the violence,” he said. “Publicly, we mourn. Publicly, we call for concern. Publicly, we support symbolic intervention. Privately, we do nothing that would actually stop it.”

A younger businessman cleared his throat. “You’re saying we let it run?”

Alfred turned his eyes on him and the man immediately regretted having spoken before understanding the room better.

“I am saying,” Alfred replied, “that violence of this type creates future dependency, future policy leverage, future construction opportunities, and future populations for systems already waiting to receive them.”

He let that settle.

“In fact, we should begin thinking ahead to more prison development. More contracts. More feed into the pipeline. We will

drain their lives and souls through our system until even their rebellion produces profit.”

No one laughed.

No one objected.

That was what made the room monstrous.

It did not need agreement spoken aloud. Agreement was already seated.

One of the politicians finally asked a practical question about timing, zoning, and public backlash. Alfred answered him cleanly, with enough strategic detail to make plain that he was not indulging in dark philosophy.

He was describing a business model.

And in that moment, the whole landscape sharpened: the rising crime, the music formatting, the public concern, the prison logic, the dead-eyed language of policy and profit all folding into one architecture.

It was enough to make a man really wonder who was in charge.

Not on paper.

In truth.

Because if Alfred Wilson could talk over white power with that kind of authority, then race alone was not the whole map of command. There were deeper tiers. Older arrangements. Hidden loyalties. Structures that used Black faces, white institutions, public sorrow, and private greed all at once.

That was the kind of room Barry Parker did not yet sit in.

But its decisions were already reaching toward his world.

Chapter Fifteen — Of Every Sector Eating and the Fall of Slim Mac

Even as danger grew in the atmosphere, the Heaven's Gates ecosystem kept producing what Barry valued most:

consistent favorable results.

Not lottery wealth.

Not fantasy riches.

Consistency.

Fashion lines were growing because artists now needed imagery with repetition behind it. Media production companies were booming because videos no longer felt like side vanity—they were part of the movement's actual commercial bloodstream. Retail spaces at the Sunset property were beginning to settle into real tenancy. Affiliate labels were upgrading their own infrastructure as Barry and Makaila had planned. Engineers, stylists, camera crews, promoters, printers, and local entrepreneurs were all eating in modest but steady ways.

That was the part outside observers often failed to understand.

Heavens Gates was not getting stronger because one or two stars caught lightning.

It was getting stronger because the ecosystem kept making room for labor to convert into livelihood.

Meanwhile Slim Mac's world was finally collapsing under the weight of all the pressure he had tried to posture through. Hector Guzman had lost patience. The dope side had turned harder. The

distributor side had turned colder. Cases and old dirt began moving faster around Slim's name. His little goons were no help. His fake bravado no longer impressed the right people. And the city could smell the decline on him even when he still dressed like a man trying to perform relevance.

The arrest came without drama worthy of the myth Slim had once tried to build around himself.

No blaze of glory.

No cinematic standoff.

Just process.

Men like Slim often imagine that if the fall comes, it will at least come with spectacle enough to protect their pride.

More often it comes with paperwork, timing, and the cold efficiency of systems no longer pretending they need your usefulness.

By the time the word spread through Columbia, Slim Mac was in custody and the city had already begun dividing the story into the usual versions. Some said he had been set up. Some said it had been coming. Some said Barry had finally finished him. Barry himself did not correct any of it publicly. He did not need the credit and had no interest in wearing another man's ruin like a trophy.

But privately, he understood exactly what had happened.

A local parasite had finally reached the end of the lane his small cunning could carry him through.

The danger, Barry knew, was that local parasites rarely disappear without their function being inherited by something bigger.

And while Columbia breathed out a little easier at the news of Slim's fall, Daniel Lemsy was just beginning to take real interest in the world that had grown strong enough to help make such a fall matter.

Chapter Sixteen — Of Dignified Distribution and the Son Who Watched the Numbers

By the time Slim had been down for nearly two years, Heavens Gates was still doing the one thing most local music movements never managed to do for long.

It kept showing up.

Not once.

Not in one quarter.

Not off one hot act or one lucky season.

It kept appearing in the numbers with a steadiness that made serious men stop treating it like regional noise and start treating it like system.

Benjamin Lemsy first really noticed that pattern the way he noticed everything that mattered: through repetition inside data.

He had been seated in a private office with sales reports laid out across his desk, SoundScan summaries marked up in pencil, retailer call sheets to one side, and three separate regional movement sheets stacked by category. His people brought him plenty of little stories every week—new artists bubbling, labels complaining, local scenes inflating themselves, quick spikes that looked exciting until you checked the return rates, the restock requests, and the durability of the routes. Benjamin had learned long ago that a lot of what the

industry called movement was really just noise wearing a nice jacket.

Heavens Gates did not look like noise.

It looked like structure.

That was what made him look again.

Then a third time.

Then with the kind of interest a man reserves for something he suspects has figured out a law everybody else keeps faking.

Benjamin was the son of Daniel Lemsy, yes, but he had not inherited the same appetite in the same direction. The bloodline was still there—England, favor, access, banking and insurance sensibility translated into music empire instinct—but Benjamin had made peace with a different kind of power. He did not mind getting rich. He minded getting rich by stealing the actual source dry. He did not believe creators had to be cheated for infrastructure to be profitable. He believed roads could make money honestly if the roads were real enough.

That was why he had built Dignified Distribution the way he had.

Retail first.

Channels first.

Backend first.

He had invested heavily in record-store chains and mom-and-pop access across the country. He understood shelf logic, restock rhythm, regional appetite, and the importance of controlling the route product traveled through once it left the artist's hand. If Daniel represented the old imperial instinct to own the soul and the shipping lane at the same time, Benjamin had developed a cleaner

formula: let the creator keep the soul, then build your wealth off the road.

So when Heaven's Gates kept appearing in the figures, Benjamin did not just see units.

He saw ecosystem.

He saw artists moving product, yes, but he also saw what must have been happening around them for that kind of consistency to hold. Shows. Merch. Packaging. Regional circulation. Repeat buyers. A network capable of carrying product farther than hometown loyalty alone. Most importantly, he saw the absence of the usual pattern where local labels flashed hard for a season, then collapsed under poor accounting, poor discipline, or too much theft built into the middle.

Heavens Gates was not collapsing.

It was multiplying.

Benjamin leaned back in his chair and tapped the page once with the eraser end of his pencil.

"Who owns this?" he asked the analyst across from him.

The man, already knowing what line he meant, replied, "Barry Parker. Columbia, South Carolina. Heavens Gates Music Group."

Benjamin nodded, eyes still on the page.

"Not just the group," he said. "Who owns the roads around it?"

The analyst hesitated. "Looks like they built more than one point of access. Studios, performance spaces, affiliate labels, independent retail support. Media too, from what we can tell."

That drew the faintest smile from Benjamin.

There it was.

Not an act.

A system.

And men who understand systems recognize one another even before they shake hands.

By the end of the week, Dignified Distribution had quietly begun assembling a fuller picture of Heavens Gates—not as a curiosity, but as a serious potential partner.

Chapter Seventeen — Of the Boardroom, the Southern Complaint, and the Father's Eye

While Benjamin was watching Heaven's Gates through numbers, Daniel Lemsy was learning its shape through complaint.

The boardroom where it came up was one of those rooms designed to make ambition feel civilized. The table was long, the wood dark, the lighting exact, the water cold enough to signal care without hospitality ever pretending to become warmth. Around that table sat men who dealt in genre, region, personality, image, and market share the way generals once dealt in terrain.

Hector Guzman was there on behalf of Soul and Fire Southern Division.

He looked like a man still holding himself together through expensive tailoring and disciplined silence, but under that polish sat irritation. Regional sales from Columbia had been declining in his flow, and he had enough intelligence to know it was not random. The old local dependence had been interrupted. The younger artists he would once have expected to route upward through familiar

channels were now being gathered, sharpened, and circulated by another machine.

He spoke on the matter when the meeting opened for regional concerns.

“Columbia, South Carolina,” he said. “We’re seeing repeated decline from that market and its satellite pull.”

Several eyes shifted. A few men glanced at supporting papers. One or two barely cared yet. Daniel cared immediately.

Hector continued, careful not to say too much in the room about what flowed beneath his public title. “The disruption appears tied to an independent ecosystem operating under the name Heavens Gates. They’re not just pulling artists. They’re affecting regional patterns. Shows, product, affiliate movement. It’s beginning to touch demand outside the immediate city.”

Daniel said nothing right away.

That was his way.

He did not grant significance with his face before deciding how he wanted the room to understand his interest. He simply made a note. Asked two brief questions about consistency, routes, and overlap. Hector answered. Another executive from another region shifted the conversation toward a separate issue, and the meeting kept going.

To lesser men, that might have looked like dismissal.

It was not.

It was assessment.

After the session ended and the room began emptying into smaller conversations, Daniel remained seated for a while with his notes in front of him. His assistant waited nearby, not interrupting. She had

worked for him long enough to know that his stillness was not delay. It was movement happening internally.

Finally he closed the folder.

“Get me the owner,” he said.

“The owner of Heavens Gates?” she asked.

Daniel stood.

“Yes.”

Nothing more needed to be said.

He had heard enough.

Not enough to panic.

Enough to understand that something independent was building without permission in a place the larger structure had learned to treat as manageable.

That alone made it worthy of attention.

And Daniel, unlike smaller men, did not wait until a threat was loud before studying how to absorb it.

Chapter Eighteen — Of the Deal, the Refusal, and the Loophole

Benjamin came first.

That mattered.

Because if Daniel had arrived first, the air around the whole thing would have felt wrong immediately. Barry would have sensed it,

even without all the details. Men like Daniel carried too much appetite in too polished a form to ever fully hide what they wanted from another builder.

Benjamin moved cleaner.

The first meeting between him and Barry took place with the quiet gravity of two men who understood roads, structure, and the difference between money that merely flashes and money that returns correctly because a system holds it in place. Benjamin did not come talking down to Columbia. He did not come speaking like he had discovered some lucky little Southern operation in need of rescue. He came with figures, patterns, routes, and respect.

Barry noticed that immediately.

Makaila did too.

Benjamin laid the offer out without fat on it.

Heavens Gates would retain one hundred percent of the royalties and one hundred percent ownership of the masters. No creative takeover. No forced narrative. No style control. No theft disguised as scale.

But Benjamin wanted what he valued most:

the road.

All Heaven's Gates product would move through Dignified Distribution and through Dignified Distribution alone.

Sole distribution rights.

Benjamin was fairer than his father, but not free of bloodline. He still believed in controlling channels. He still believed that if his infrastructure was what elevated the next phase of a movement, then that movement should travel through his circuit and his circuit

only. It was empire instinct, cleaned up by conscience and defended by math.

Barry understood the distinction.

He also understood the opportunity.

He did not need to own every lane at once in order to remain sovereign where it mattered most. Keeping the masters and the royalties meant keeping the soul of the thing. Sole distribution through Benjamin meant using an existing road without pretending that borrowing a road was the same as surrendering the kingdom.

So Barry listened.

Asked what needed to be asked.

Let Makaila probe the numbers, backend arrangements, shelf access, retailer terms, return protections, physical product flow, and all the other machinery that men without real systems understanding usually leave to chance.

Benjamin appreciated that too. It told him he was not dealing with dreamers. He was dealing with owners.

By the end of the negotiations, the agreement was done.

Heavens Gates would keep the music.

Benjamin would keep the road.

That alone would have made the season historic.

But Daniel still came.

He approached Barry with the kind of elegance that always made refusal more expensive socially than acceptance. He did not speak as crudely as lesser predators did. He spoke in broader terms—reach, narrative alignment, international possibility, style

shaping, market acceleration, umbrella protection, long-term industry consolidation. Underneath it all sat the true desire plainly enough for a man like Barry to hear it:

capture.

Daniel wanted the flow.

He wanted the narrative.

He wanted the styles under certain labels to fit specific agendas.

He wanted to get inside Heaven's Gates before it became too large to absorb without open war.

Barry turned him down.

Not loudly.

Not with a speech.

Not with artificial masculinity meant to prove he was unbought.

He simply refused.

That made the refusal heavier.

Daniel was not a man used to being denied calmly by someone he had already begun categorizing as a useful future subordinate.

Still, he did not show offense.

He showed what he always showed.

Control.

But control is not the same thing as surrender.

He pivoted almost immediately.

The first sign that something had shifted did not come from Daniel Lemsky.

It came through Slim's lawyer.

By then Slim had already started settling into the kind of prison bitterness that turns a man smaller on the inside before it ever fully shows on his face. His narcotics contact had been exposed, demoted, disgraced, and then gone out of the world by his own hand. The paperwork around the old case had started looking less sturdy. Men inside kept hearing rumors the way men inside always do—half truth, half hope, half poison—but Slim had been around too many lies to trust movement before he saw it touch his own name.

Then his lawyer came.

Not with excitement. Not with false comfort. Just with that restrained professional energy lawyers use when they know a development is real enough to matter but not yet safe enough to celebrate.

Slim sat across from him in the visitation room trying to look less eager than he felt.

"What you got?" he asked.

The lawyer opened his folder and adjusted his glasses.

"There's an opening."

Slim stared.

"What kind of opening?"

"The corruption tied to your former narcotics contact has complicated the integrity of parts of the case history. There are weaknesses. Enough to move on."

Slim leaned in.

"You saying I'm coming home?"

The lawyer did not hand him that much too early.

“I’m saying there is now room to seek an appeal bond, and I believe we have a real shot.”

Slim sat back slowly.

For a long second he said nothing.

Not because he was calm.

Because his body had not caught up yet to the possibility that the wall he thought was fixed might actually have a crack in it.

The lawyer continued explaining. Procedure. Timing. Filing strategy. Exposure of misconduct. Weakness in the chain. Technical openings. Slim heard some of it. Not all of it. Men like Slim rarely hear legal structure clean once hope turns loud in their chest.

“What changed?” Slim finally asked.

The lawyer paused only briefly.

“Circumstances.”

That answer was true in the most incomplete way.

Slim accepted it because he wanted to.

And from that point on, he treated the appeal like a miracle he had somehow earned rather than a corridor somebody else might already be widening for reasons beyond him.

When the bond finally came through and the gate opened, the first thing Slim tasted was not gratitude.

It was appetite.

Freedom hit him like old liquor. Too fast. Too warm. Too flattering.

The car waiting for him was black, quiet, and too refined to belong to any of the little local hands he once called allies. His lawyer was already inside.

Slim got in and looked at him sideways.

“So who the hell really behind this?”

The lawyer straightened his cuff and gave him the kind of answer that says more by refusing than by naming.

“You’re being given an opportunity,” he said. “Don’t waste it by asking the wrong questions too early.”

Slim frowned, but he was too freshly free to press the point hard. He sat back and let the city begin returning to him through tinted glass—streets, lights, buildings, motion, all of it looking both familiar and far away.

He did not know where they were taking him until they arrived.

Only then did he understand that freedom had not come alone.

It had come with an introduction.

The room he was led into was understated, expensive, and quiet in the way only deeply financed places can afford to be. Slim entered with the lawyer at his side and saw Daniel Lemsky waiting.

That was the first time they met face to face.

Slim knew the name immediately, of course. Anybody in music who knew anything beyond the local level knew it. But knowing a name and standing in front of the man attached to it are two different experiences.

Daniel did not greet him like an equal.

He greeted him like a man assessing whether the returned instrument in front of him would play the kind of note he needed.

Slim felt that instantly.

He also ignored it instantly.

Because freedom, money, and revenge were already louder in him than discernment.

Daniel motioned for him to sit.

Slim did.

The lawyer remained nearby, quiet and necessary, his part in the corridor now largely complete.

Daniel opened the folder.

And the future, poisoned as it was, began.

“You have been given an opportunity,” Daniel said.

Slim nodded like that much was obvious.

Daniel continued. “Your appeal bond is the first opening, not the final victory. The rest depends on how valuable you are prepared to become.”

That made Slim sit up straighter.

Because there it was.

Value.

Men like Slim loved being told they were valuable almost as much as they loved being told they were feared.

Daniel opened the folder.

“Lemsky Universal is prepared to place you under the umbrella.”

Slim's eyes sharpened.

Not from wisdom.

From appetite.

Daniel went on with the same calm tone. "You will have access to an annual operating budget of two hundred million dollars. Fifty million will be allocated against your catalog acquisition and repositioning. Your music and label can be reintroduced at scale."

Slim heard freedom.

He heard money.

He heard revenge.

He did not hear cage.

Daniel, of course, heard all three.

"There are conditions," Daniel said.

Slim barely cared, but he knew enough to keep his face serious.

"Such as?"

"We control the flow and the narrative of your music. Certain styles from certain labels will be prioritized according to our marketing agenda. Distribution, release strategy, visibility, and placement will move through our structure. You will operate with resources, but not without direction."

Slim leaned back and almost laughed.

Not because he found it funny.

Because to him the trade was so obviously worth it that the conditions barely registered as cost.

Be free.

Have backing.

Get paid.

Have a real budget.

Finally get the machine behind your weak-ass records and your broken label dream.

To Slim, that sounded like arrival.

To Daniel, it was acquisition.

Slim looked at the papers again and shook his head once like he still couldn't believe his luck.

"So let me get this straight," he said. "I'm out, I'm funded, and I get to run it back?"

Daniel's face did not move.

"You get to return," he said. "Whether you run it correctly remains to be seen."

Slim grinned anyway.

That local greed came right back up in him.

"Nigga, I'm down."

Daniel did not correct the language. He had no need to. A man like Slim often revealed his limitations more efficiently when left comfortable enough to do so in his own mouth.

Slim signed.

That was all it took.

No wrestling with principle.

No concern over narrative control.

No question about whether he was being bought as a weapon against another Black man's rising system.

Freedom, vanity, and funding had already answered all moral questions for him before they could fully form.

Daniel closed the folder and stood.

The meeting was over in his mind before Slim had finished enjoying the fantasy of his own restoration.

As Slim was escorted out, his thoughts were loud with everything he believed had just been returned to him:

his status,
his future,
his revenge,
his music,
his city.

He did not yet understand that none of those things had been given back clean.

Daniel waited until the door shut before speaking again, this time to the assistant who had remained quietly at the edge of the room.

"Have him built carefully," Daniel said. "Men like that collapse when they are given too much rope too quickly."

The assistant nodded.

"And Barry Parker?" she asked.

Daniel looked back out the window.

For a long second, the room held nothing but the kind of silence old empires use to think in.

Then he said, “If he would not come under the structure, then the structure will come around him.”

That was how Book Two truly closed.

Not with defeat.

Not even with victory.

With proof.

Heavens Gates had risen.

The deal with Benjamin was real.

The state had been bridged.

The system had worked.

And because it had worked, larger forces had now decided it could no longer be ignored.

Thus ended The Heavens Rising, being Book Two of the Heavens Gates Chronicles.